

# Paschim Banga Divas (West Bengal Day)

*A sourced timeline of the 1947 partition of Bengal, separating verified dated facts from historical interpretation and current political claims*

This document compiles dated, independently verifiable facts about the partition of Bengal and the creation of West Bengal in 1947, drawn from academic histories, government/legislative records, and established news archives. A separate section then addresses points that are genuinely matters of historical interpretation or live political dispute, clearly marked as such, so the two categories are not mixed together.

## 1. Verified Timeline

| Date                        | Verified event                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
|-----------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>1932</b>                 | British Communal Award restructures Bengal's legislative seats along communal lines, sharpening Hindu–Muslim electoral competition in the province.                                                                                                                                            |
| <b>1937</b>                 | Provincial elections under the Government of India Act, 1935; A.K. Fazlul Huq's Krishak Praja Party forms a coalition ministry with the Muslim League. Syama Prasad Mookerjee, elected as an independent, becomes Leader of the Opposition and later joins this coalition as Finance Minister. |
| <b>Dec 1939</b>             | Hindu Mahasabha is formally launched as an organised political force in Calcutta.                                                                                                                                                                                                              |
| <b>Mar 1940</b>             | Muslim League's Lahore Resolution formalises the demand for separate Muslim-majority states (the basis of the later Pakistan demand).                                                                                                                                                          |
| <b>1942</b>                 | Mookerjee resigns from the Bengal coalition ministry after demanding self-rule for Indians; he is later prominent in famine-relief efforts during the 1943 Bengal famine.                                                                                                                      |
| <b>16–19 Aug 1946</b>       | 'Direct Action Day', called by the Muslim League, leads to the Great Calcutta Killing, with several thousand deaths across communities.                                                                                                                                                        |
| <b>Oct 1946</b>             | Noakhali riots: communal violence in eastern Bengal disproportionately affecting Hindus.                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
| <b>20 Feb 1947</b>          | British government (PM Clement Attlee) announces its intention to transfer power in British India by June 1948.                                                                                                                                                                                |
| <b>5 Apr 1947</b>           | Bengal Provincial Hindu Conference at Tarakeshwar, presided over by Mookerjee, passes a resolution for a separate Bengali Hindu homeland within India and authorises Mookerjee to organise a partition campaign.                                                                               |
| <b>23 Apr 1947</b>          | Mookerjee meets Viceroy Lord Mountbatten and argues the case for partitioning Bengal.                                                                                                                                                                                                          |
| <b>2 May 1947</b>           | Mookerjee sends a detailed letter to Mountbatten arguing that a sovereign, undivided Bengal would in practice become 'a virtual Pakistan'.                                                                                                                                                     |
| <b>3 May 1947</b>           | Scheduled Caste representatives from eastern Bengal meet Mountbatten and separately demand partition, seeking relocation of Scheduled Caste populations to a proposed Bengali Hindu homeland in the west.                                                                                      |
| <b>8 May 1947 (approx.)</b> | Huseyn Shaheed Suhrawardy, Sarat Chandra Bose and Kiran Shankar Roy propose an alternative 'United Bengal' plan — an independent, undivided Bengal outside both India and Pakistan.                                                                                                            |
| <b>9–14 May 1947</b>        | Mahatma Gandhi holds talks with Hindu and Muslim Bengal leaders at Sodepur, attempting to find a basis for keeping Bengal united.                                                                                                                                                              |

| Date                  | Verified event                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
|-----------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>30 May 1947</b>    | Nehru and Patel, in talks with Mountbatten in Delhi, reject the proposed exception that would have allowed Bengal to remain undivided/sovereign.                                                                                                    |
| <b>3 Jun 1947</b>     | Mountbatten formally announces the partition plan (the 'June 3 Plan' / Mountbatten Plan), providing that the Bengal and Punjab legislatures would each vote on partition.                                                                           |
| <b>20 Jun 1947</b>    | Bengal Legislative Assembly holds three linked votes (see table below). The Hindu-majority bloc votes 58–21 in favour of partition and joining India — the vote now commemorated as the basis of West Bengal's separate existence.                  |
| <b>6 Jul 1947</b>     | Sylhet referendum: voters choose to separate Sylhet from Assam and merge it into East Bengal (Pakistan).                                                                                                                                            |
| <b>18 Jul 1947</b>    | British Parliament passes the Indian Independence Act, 1947, giving legal effect to the partition and the transfer of power.                                                                                                                        |
| <b>14–15 Aug 1947</b> | Pakistan and India become independent dominions; West Bengal and East Bengal formally come into existence as separate provinces.                                                                                                                    |
| <b>17 Aug 1947</b>    | The Radcliffe Line (Bengal Boundary Commission award, chaired by Sir Cyril Radcliffe) is published, finalising the India–Pakistan border through Bengal.                                                                                            |
| <b>1947–1951</b>      | Large-scale cross-border migration: the 1951 Indian census records roughly 2.5 million people born in East Pakistan resident in India, the great majority in West Bengal.                                                                           |
| <b>1971</b>           | Bangladesh Liberation War; East Pakistan becomes the independent state of Bangladesh.                                                                                                                                                               |
| <b>7 Sep 2023</b>     | West Bengal Legislative Assembly passes a resolution (boycotted by the BJP) adopting Poila Boishakh (Bengali New Year) as the state's official 'Bangla Divas', rather than 20 June.                                                                 |
| <b>2023–2025</b>      | Raj Bhavans in several other Indian states (under centrally-appointed Governors) begin holding 'West Bengal Foundation Day' events on 20 June; West Bengal's own state administration does not organise official June 20 events during this period. |
| <b>Jun 2026</b>       | The BJP-led West Bengal state government (under Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari) issues an official order to observe 'Paschimbanga Divas' on 20 June across district headquarters and educational institutions.                                     |

## 2. The 20 June 1947 Votes, in Detail

Under the Mountbatten Plan, partition would be triggered if either the Hindu-majority or Muslim-majority bloc of the Bengal Assembly voted for it, regardless of what the other bloc or the full house preferred. All three of the following votes took place in a single day.

| Session                                            | Vote                                                                                   | Result                                                                              |
|----------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Joint sitting, full Bengal Assembly                | Whether province should join the new Pakistan Constituent Assembly if it stayed united | 126 against remaining united under Pakistan / 90 in favour                          |
| Separate sitting, Muslim-majority-area legislators | Whether Bengal should be partitioned                                                   | 106 against partition / 35 for partition (i.e. wanted undivided Bengal in Pakistan) |
| Separate sitting, Hindu-majority-area legislators  | Whether Bengal should be partitioned and the western part join India                   | 58 in favour of partition / 21 against                                              |

*Note: The full-house vote favoured staying united; it was the separate, bloc-wise vote of Hindu-majority-area legislators that actually triggered partition under the plan's rules.*

### 3. Key Figures — Documented Roles

The events of 1947 involved many actors operating at different levels (national/constitutional, provincial/legislative, and grassroots/mobilisational). The table below states only what is documented in primary correspondence, legislative records, or established academic histories.

| Figure / role                                                                        | Documented, source-backed role                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |
|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Syama Prasad Mookerjee</b><br>(President, All-India Hindu Mahasabha)              | Led the regional campaign for partitioning Bengal along Hindu-majority lines from April 1947 onward; met Mountbatten on 23 April 1947 and wrote to him on 2 May 1947 arguing for partition; presided over the 5 April 1947 Tarakeshwar resolution; organised the Hindu-majority legislative bloc that produced the 58–21 vote on 20 June 1947. Sources indicate he worked for Hindu–Muslim co-existence into 1946 and turned to advocating partition only after the failure of unity efforts, including Gandhi's, during the Noakhali crisis. |
| <b>Jawaharlal Nehru</b><br>(Congress, Vice-President, Interim Government)            | Did not personally lead or originate the Bengal partition campaign. At the national level, jointly with Patel, rejected (30 May 1947) the proposal to exempt Bengal from partition / allow a sovereign united Bengal, which led directly to Mountbatten announcing the partition framework on 3 June 1947. This national-level decision was a precondition for the 20 June vote taking place at all.                                                                                                                                          |
| <b>Vallabhbhai Patel</b><br>(Congress, Home Member, Interim Government)              | Worked closely with V.P. Menon in shaping the partition mechanism (the 'June 3 Plan'); accepted it as the only workable option once the Cabinet Mission Plan had failed. Jointly with Nehru, rejected the 'United Bengal' exception on 30 May 1947.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                           |
| <b>Bidhan Chandra Roy</b><br>(Bengal Congress)                                       | Attended the 5 April 1947 Tarakeshwar conference alongside Mookerjee; later became West Bengal's second Chief Minister (1948–1962), focusing chiefly on post-partition reconstruction, refugee rehabilitation, and industrial development rather than the partition campaign itself.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |
| <b>Kiran Shankar Roy, Sarat Chandra Bose</b><br>(Bengal Congress, pro-unity faction) | Co-proposed, with Muslim League leader H.S. Suhrawardy, a rival 'United Bengal' plan — an independent, undivided Bengal outside both India and Pakistan. This plan was rejected by both the Congress high command in Delhi and by Mookerjee's faction, for differing reasons, and did not go forward.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |
| <b>Bengal Pradesh Congress Committee</b>                                             | Passed its own provincial resolution backing Bengal's partition, operating in parallel with, though organisationally separate from, Mookerjee's Hindu Mahasabha campaign.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
| <b>Lord Mountbatten</b><br>(Viceroy of India)                                        | Announced the partition framework (3 June Plan) after the 30 May 1947 Delhi talks; met separately with Mookerjee (23 April) and received his letter (2 May) urging partition.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
| <b>Sir Cyril Radcliffe</b><br>(Chair, Bengal Boundary Commission)                    | Drew the final India–Pakistan border through Bengal (the Radcliffe Line), published 17 August 1947, two days after independence — separate from, and after, the 20 June legislative vote.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |

### 4. Where This Becomes Interpretation, Not Settled Fact

The items above are dated, source-backed events. The questions below — who 'built' West Bengal, whether 20 June should be celebrated, and how much credit belongs to which leader — are not questions with a single factual answer. They are framed differently by different historians and by current political parties. Each box below states a real position and identifies who holds it; none should be read as this document's own conclusion.

**A. 'Mookerjee was the principal architect of West Bengal' (a position associated with the BJP and with sympathetic historical accounts)**

This view holds that without Mookerjee's sustained advocacy and organisation of the Hindu-majority legislative bloc, Bengal as a whole might have joined Pakistan en bloc, or accepted the rival 'United Bengal' plan, leaving Bengali Hindus a permanent minority. It credits him with directly preventing that outcome through the 20 June vote.

**B. 'Partition was driven by elite Hindu bhadralok self-interest, not a singular act of statesmanship' (associated with historian Joya Chatterji's academic work, and broadly with left/secular historiography)**

This view holds that the partition campaign reflected a shift among Bengal's upper-caste Hindu elite from broad-based nationalism toward communal self-protection from the 1930s onward, and that Mookerjee became the figurehead of a pre-existing bhadralok mobilisation rather than its sole originator. It also argues the rejected 'United Bengal' plan deserves more attention than it usually receives.

**C. 'A more sympathetic, document-based re-reading of Mookerjee' (associated with historian Chhanda Chatterjee's 2020 study, which is more favourable than (B) but more cautious than (A))**

This more recent academic study argues both the 'triumphalist' and 'arch-communalist' framings oversimplify the record: Mookerjee pursued Hindu-Muslim co-existence formulas until late 1946, and only turned to advocating partition after other options, including Gandhi's own mediation, had failed.

**D. 'Nehru and Congress, not Mookerjee, were primarily responsible for West Bengal's existence' (a less common claim, partially supported by the procedural record)**

It is factually accurate that Nehru and Patel's rejection of the 'United Bengal' exception on 30 May 1947 was what made the 3 June Plan — and therefore the 20 June vote — possible at all. However, the documentary record does not show Nehru personally campaigning for, or originating, the demand to partition Bengal along Hindu-majority lines the way Mookerjee did; his role was at the level of national constitutional negotiation, not regional mobilisation. Treating this as equivalent to Mookerjee's role, or as the dominant cause of West Bengal's specific shape, is not well supported by the primary record.

**E. 'June 20 should / should not be a celebratory Foundation Day' (the live TMC–BJP political dispute)**

The BJP-led state government's 2026 order frames 20 June as marking 'the partition of Bengal within India' and a basis for state pride. The Trinamool Congress government previously designated Poila Boishakh (Bengali New Year) as the state's official day instead, on the grounds that 20 June is inseparable from Partition's violence and mass displacement and is therefore unsuitable as a celebratory date. Both positions accept the same underlying 1947 facts; they differ on how those facts should be commemorated.

## 5. Summary Answer to 'How Much Credit Belongs to Whom'

Based on the documented record: Syama Prasad Mookerjee is well-supported as the leading *regional*, *mobilisational* figure behind the specific Hindu-majority partition campaign and the 20 June vote. Nehru and Patel are well-supported as the figures whose *national-level*, *procedural* decisions (rejecting a sovereign united Bengal, accepting the province-splitting mechanism) made that vote possible in the first place. Neither role substitutes for the other, and crediting either man as the sole 'founder' of West Bengal simplifies a process that also involved the Bengal Pradesh Congress, B.C. Roy, the rejected Suhrawardy–Bose–Roy unity plan, Mountbatten's office, and Radcliffe's boundary commission. Treating this as a single-architect story — in either direction — is a political simplification rather than a historical finding.

*This document distinguishes dated facts (Sections 1–3) from contested interpretation (Section 4) deliberately. Readers are encouraged to consult the primary sources listed below directly.*

## 6. Sources

- Banglapedia, 'Partition of Bengal, 1947' — [en.banglapedia.org](http://en.banglapedia.org)
- Wikipedia, 'West Bengal Day' — [en.wikipedia.org/wiki/West\\_Bengal\\_Day](http://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/West_Bengal_Day)
- Joya Chatterji, *Bengal Divided: Hindu Communalism and Partition, 1932–1947* (Cambridge University Press, 1994/2002)
- Joya Chatterji, *The Spoils of Partition: Bengal and India, 1947–1967* (Cambridge University Press, 2007)
- Chhanda Chatterjee, *Syama Prasad Mookerjee, the Hindu Dissent and the Partition of Bengal, 1932–1947* (Routledge, 2020)
- Constitution of India website, biographical entry on Syama Prasad Mookerjee — [constitutionofindia.net](http://constitutionofindia.net)
- The Daily Star (Dhaka), 'Partition 1947: Partition or Unity? Bengal in 1947' — [thedailystar.net](http://thedailystar.net)
- The Caravan, 'The historical roots of Hindu majoritarianism in West Bengal' — [caravanmagazine.in](http://caravanmagazine.in)
- The Statesman, review of Chhanda Chatterjee's study — [thestatesman.com](http://thestatesman.com)
- Scroll.in, 'Three facts about BJP founder SP Mookerjee...' — [scroll.in](http://scroll.in)
- The Statesman, 'Bengal to observe Paschimbanga Divas on June 20' (2026) — [thestatesman.com](http://thestatesman.com)
- IANS / Prokerala, 'Foundation days are not to erase or ignore pain...' (2026) — [ianslive.in](http://ianslive.in) / [prokerala.com](http://prokerala.com)
- The Hindu, coverage of the 2023 West Bengal Assembly resolution on Poila Boishakh — [thehindu.com](http://thehindu.com)
- NextIAS / IndiaStateStory, explainers on the Mountbatten Plan (3 June Plan) and the Menon Plan
- EPFL Graph Search / Wikipedia data summary on the Partition of Bengal (1947) vote counts

---

Compiled from publicly available historical scholarship and news archives. Political interpretation sections (4–5) present multiple documented positions rather than endorsing any single one.